

THE SELLER'S GUIDE

An Insider's Guide to Selling Your Home in *San Francisco*

A teach-first walk-through of how your home actually gets sold here — the pricing, the paperwork, the timeline, and the number that lands in your pocket.

First, and *foremost*.

You're about to sell what's probably your largest asset, in one of the most competitive markets in the country. How you go about it matters — so thank you for letting me walk you through it.

I made this guide because I teach first. Before we ever talk price or timing, I want you to actually understand the moves in front of you — a seller who gets the strategy makes calmer, better decisions, and calm decisions are what protect your equity.

So this isn't a pitch. It's the plain-English version of everything I wish every seller knew before they listed: what your home is really worth, the SF paperwork nobody warns you about, what's worth fixing and what isn't, and what selling actually costs when the dust settles.

Read it at your own pace. There's no clock running, and there's no pressure from me. When you're ready to talk about your specific home, I'll be right here.

MY ONE PROMISE

I'll never hand you a price without seeing your home in person and running the comps. No automated Zestimate, no number over text to win your business. Anyone who blurts a figure before they've seen your kitchen is selling you, not helping you.

claudia lee



“My job isn't to sell your home. It's to guide you to make empowered, educated decisions that protect your equity and match your timeline. The right strategy, the right way.”

— CLAUDIA

WHO I AM, BRIEFLY

An SF REALTOR® at Vantage, running the *Claudia Insider* brand on one idea: real estate should be taught, not sold. I bring the branding, marketing, and tech side of a modern home sale — backed by a hyper-local team with deep SF experience. A little more on both of us, next page.

Fun fact — I'm a 3× US national team member and multiple-time national karate champion. Turns out staying calm under pressure is a very transferable skill.

Have a question — any question? I mean it. Reach out anytime, no commitment required.

A hyper-local team, and a *human* to run it.

You're not hiring one person — you're getting a boutique San Francisco firm behind you, and an agent who genuinely loves the presentation side. Here's the pairing that goes to work on your listing.

THE TEAM — YOUR SUPPORT

Vantage agents are hyper-local — we work San Francisco neighborhoods daily and know the micro-markets, the building histories, and the listing agents by name. That matters when we're pricing your home, negotiating offers, or spotting something that needs attention before it hits the market.

Vantage runs on **Side** — the operating platform that handles compliance, legal, and transaction support behind the scenes so we can focus entirely on our clients. You get a small, focused team with institutional-grade infrastructure underneath.



WHAT I BRING — YOUR LEAD

Branding & marketing — presenting your home is what I do all day. Media, a property website, and social reach that actually moves.

Tech-savvy launch — a modern, polished rollout, not a tired MLS post.

Detail-oriented project management — anticipating issues, coordinating every vendor, and keeping the entire process on track.

A human to work with — collaborative, clear, and low-stress.

THE VANTAGE TEAM · REALTRENDS VERIFIED, 2025

#1

SF LARGE TEAM
AVG. SALE PRICE

#3

SF LARGE TEAM
BY SALES VOLUME

\$600M+

SOLD SINCE
FOUNDING, 2023

\$230M+

VOLUME
YEAR-TO-DATE

Top 0.1%

IN CA & U.S.
REALTRENDS

Vantage Realty team performance — RealTrends-verified (2025), and a Leading 100 Bay Area team.

A top-performing brokerage behind you, plus a marketing-forward agent who keeps it human. That's what working with me looks like.

YOUR CORNER

What's *inside*.

Twelve short chapters, in the order they'll actually happen. Skip around if you like — but if you read only three, make them pricing, the SF paperwork, and what it all costs. Those are where sales are quietly won or lost.

- | | | | |
|-----------|---|-----------|---|
| 01 | Is it the right time — for you?
Reading the SF market for your situation, not the headlines. | 07 | What good marketing looks like
What to look for — not a highlight reel. |
| 02 | What your home is really worth
Comps, why list price is marketing, and the SF underpricing game. | 08 | Offers & negotiation
Why the highest offer isn't always the best one. |
| 03 | Getting your home ready
What's worth doing, what to skip, and the ROI reality. | 09 | What selling actually costs
Commissions, SF transfer tax, and your net sheet. |
| 04 | The paperwork most sellers don't expect
The disclosure package, inspections, and SF-only reports. | 10 | Selling and buying at once
The whiplash, and how people pull it off. |
| 05 | Condos, TICs & multi-unit
The extra steps when it's not a single-family home. | 11 | Closing & the little things
Escrow, PG&E, Recology, keys, done. |
| 06 | The timeline & what to expect
Decision to close, in realistic weeks. | 12 | A note to end on
No hard sell. Just an open door. |

The only market that matters is *yours*.

Headlines love to declare that "the market" is hot or cold — but the market that matters is the one for your specific home, in your specific neighborhood, at the moment you're actually ready to move.

Timing a sale isn't about reading the city-wide median and picking a month. It's about **your life** — the move, the school year, the next chapter — and then aligning that with what the local data says about your micro-market right now.

Spring is the classic SF season, yes. But condos in SoMa trade differently than Victorians in Noe. A two-unit in the Sunset has its own rhythm. And comps move by the day and the week, not month to month.

The honest answer to "is it a good time to sell?" is almost always: *it depends on your situation*. That's why the first thing I do is sit with you — not pull up a national chart — and look at the recent, hyper-local activity for homes like yours.



THE INSIDER BIT

San Francisco's spring market typically heats up in late February and peaks around April–May. But here's the nuance most agents skip: the *best* window for your home might not be the busiest month — it's the week when your competition is thinnest.

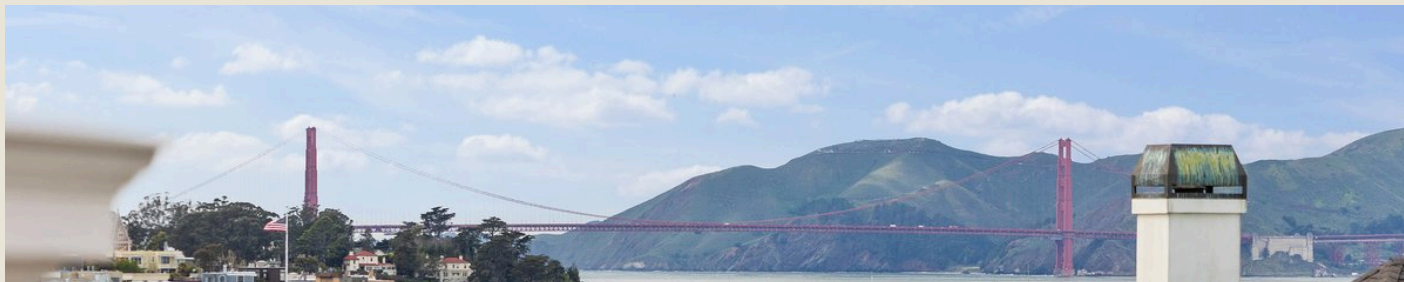
A great listing in a slower month can outperform a good listing in a crowded one. [Strategy >](#) calendar.

WHAT I'LL BRING YOU

- A hyper-local CMA specific to your home — not a zip-code average.
- Absorption-rate data: how fast homes like yours are actually selling right now.
- A candid read on what's coming to market in your area — so you know your likely competition.
- An honest opinion. If the timing isn't right, I'll say so.

"Not sure yet" is a completely fine answer. My job in that season is to keep you informed until the timing is genuinely right — no pressure to move before it is.

List price is marketing. *Value* is what a buyer pays.



There are two different numbers every seller needs to understand: the price you list at, and the price you ultimately get. In San Francisco, those numbers are often intentionally different — and the gap between them is strategy, not accident.

In many SF neighborhoods, the standard move is to **underprice** — list below market value to create urgency, attract multiple offers, and let competition drive the final number above asking. Done well, it works. Done poorly, it backfires spectacularly.

The key is knowing *where* your home sits. A well-located, well-presented property in a hot micro-market? Underpricing can generate fierce bidding. A home that's more niche, or in a softer pocket? Pricing at value — or even slightly above — might be the smarter play.

WHY OVERPRICING QUIETLY COSTS YOU

An overpriced listing doesn't just sit — it actively helps your neighbors sell. Buyers use your home as the "see, this one is better for less" comparison. Meanwhile, days on market climb, the listing goes stale, and when you finally reduce, the market reads it as desperation.

The data is relentless: homes that price correctly from day one sell faster *and* for more.

WHERE UNDERPRICING DOES NOT APPLY

Not every property benefits from listing low. Luxury homes above \$3–4M, unique properties with a small buyer pool, and homes in neighborhoods where bidding wars are rare — these often do better priced at or near actual value.

Knowing which strategy fits your specific home is the entire job.

THE CMA — AKA MY HONEST READ

A Comparative Market Analysis is how we figure out what your home is actually worth. I pull recently sold comps — same neighborhood, similar size, recent close dates — and adjust for your home's specific condition, upgrades, and quirks.

It's not a formula. It's a judgment call backed by data, and I'll walk you through every line.

WHY WE SET PRICE CLOSE TO LAUNCH

We finalize list price close to going live because the market shifts. Comps from two months ago may already be stale. The price decision is one of the last ones we make — deliberately.

Spend where it *pays back*. Skip where it doesn't.



Prep is a menu, not a mandate. Some improvements deliver a clear return; others are money you'll never see again. Here's the honest breakdown — and we'll tailor it to your home specifically.

USUALLY WORTH IT RELIABLE RETURN

- Staging
- Fresh paint
- Deep clean
- Refinishing floors
- Lighting refresh
- Curb appeal
- Small repairs
- Pro photography

IT DEPENDS SITUATIONAL

- New flooring
- Kitchen refresh
- Countertops/lighting
- Pre-sale inspections

USUALLY SKIP RARELY RECOUPED

- Full kitchen remodel
- Additions
- HVAC swaps
- Bold personal finish choices

STAGING, HONESTLY

Staging in SF typically runs \$3,000–\$8,000+ for a full home, depending on size and duration. It's one of the highest-ROI moves you can make — staged homes routinely sell faster and for more. But it's not always necessary for every property. We'll look at your specific situation and decide together.

HOW I KEEP PREP OFF YOUR PLATE

I have a roster of trusted vendors — painters, stagers, cleaners, handypeople — who know the drill and work on listing timelines. I coordinate the schedule, get you quotes, and keep the whole thing moving so you don't have to project-manage your own sale.

The disclosure package — aka your home's *baggage*.

In San Francisco, the seller prepares a full disclosure package *before* going to market — not after an offer comes in. It's one of the city's biggest quirks, and one of the most important things to get right.

WHAT GOES IN THE PACKAGE

- **Your seller disclosures** — what you know about the property's condition, history, and any material facts. This is your legal obligation as a seller.
- **Natural Hazard Disclosure (NHD)** — earthquake zones, flood zones, fire risk. A third-party report we order for you.
- **Lead-based paint disclosure** — required for homes built before 1978.
- **Agent Visual Inspection Disclosure (AVID)** — my own walk-through notes on the property's visible condition.
- **Preliminary title report** — confirms ownership, liens, and easements. We order this from the title company.

THE SF-SPECIFIC REPORTS

- **The 3R Report** — a city-issued report showing permits, complaints, and any open violations on your property. Unique to San Francisco.
- **Pre-sale pest/WDO inspection** — a wood-destroying organism report. Buyers expect it; providing it upfront removes a negotiation lever.
- **General/property inspection** — optional but increasingly standard. Getting ahead of surprises protects your deal.
- **Energy & water compliance** — San Francisco has specific efficiency requirements that sellers must certify.
- **Sometimes: sewer lateral, roof, foundation** — depending on the property, additional inspections may be wise or expected.

WHY "GET AHEAD OF IT" IS THE WHOLE GAME

A complete, transparent disclosure package does two things: it makes buyers confident enough to write strong offers, and it removes the ammunition for renegotiation after you're in contract. Surprises kill deals. Transparency protects them.

Note: report costs and requirements can shift — I'll walk you through the current specifics when we start your package.

Condos, TICs & multi-unit: the *extra* steps.

Single-family homes are the straightforward path. If you're selling a condo, TIC, or multi-unit building, there are additional layers — and getting them wrong can stall or torpedo your sale.

01

IF IT'S A CONDO

The HOA docs

Buyers and their lenders will scrutinize the HOA's financials, reserves, insurance, CC&Rs, meeting minutes, and any pending litigation or special assessments. A weak HOA package is a deal-killer — especially for financed buyers. I'll help you pull a complete, current set and flag anything that needs context.

02

IF IT'S A TIC

One parcel, shared

Tenancy-in-Common ownership means you share one deed with your co-owners. Financing is trickier, insurance is shared, and the TIC agreement itself — who pays for what, how decisions are made — is a document buyers read carefully. We need to present it clearly and address the common concerns upfront.

03

IF THERE ARE TENANTS

Rent control & rights

San Francisco rent control applies to most multi-unit buildings built before June 1979. Tenants have significant rights — just cause eviction, relocation payments, right of first refusal in some cases. Selling with tenants in place requires careful handling, legal guidance, and transparency with buyers about the rental situation.

THE VALUE LEVER NOBODY EXPLAINS

A TIC that's eligible for condo conversion is worth significantly more than one that isn't. The city's lottery system, bypass options, and recent legislative changes all affect your property's conversion potential — and its price. This is one of the first things I research for TIC sellers.

DECKS, BALCONIES & BIG BUILDINGS

If your condo is in a building with a deck, shared roof access, or more than a handful of units, there may be additional city compliance issues — SB 326 balcony inspections, fire safety, elevator certifications. These are increasingly required as part of the disclosure package, and buyers (and their agents) are asking for them.



Decision to closed, in *real* weeks.

Every sale is different, but this is the typical rhythm. Think of it as a rough map, not a contract.

- **Decide & prep**
≈ 3–12 WEEKS
 Interviews, strategy, disclosures, inspections, staging, photography — the foundation.
- **Coming soon**
≈ 1 WEEK
 A soft preview on the MLS to build buzz before the full launch.
- **Live on the market**
≈ 1–2 WEEKS
 Open houses, showings, broker tours — the full push.
- **Offer date**
A SINGLE DAY
 Offers come in, we review, negotiate, and accept.
- **In escrow**
≈ 3–6 WEEKS
 Buyer's loan, appraisal, final contingencies, signing.
- **Closed**
KEYS HANDED OVER



OPEN-HOUSE DAY IS THE BIG ONE

The first open house is your home's debut. We want it fully staged, spotlessly clean, and strategically marketed before that door opens. First impressions in SF's market are worth tens of thousands of dollars — this is not the day to wing it.

YOU'LL HEAR FROM ME — A LOT

During active marketing, I send you showing feedback, open-house traffic numbers, and agent intel as it comes in — not in a weekly summary you have to chase. You'll always know where things stand.

Ranges are typical for San Francisco — your timeline may be shorter or longer depending on property type and market conditions.

What to *look for* — not a highlight reel.

Every agent will tell you they "do great marketing." Here's how to actually tell. Strong marketing isn't one beautiful photo — it's a coordinated launch built to create urgency in the first two weeks, when buyer attention is highest.

The pieces that matter:

- **Professional photography** — not phone photos, not a friend with a camera. Architectural-grade images that make your home look the way it feels in person.
- **Dedicated property website** — a single URL for your listing with all the media, disclosures, and details in one place.
- **Floor plans** — buyers in SF are obsessed with layout. This is non-negotiable for a competitive listing.
- **Video & 3D walk-through** — especially for out-of-area buyers, this is how they decide to fly in for a showing.
- **Coming-soon/just-listed reach** — email blasts, social media, broker networks — all timed around launch day.
- **Broker tour + real open house** — not a checkbox event. A well-run open house is a sales tool.



WHERE I'M GENUINELY DIFFERENT

I come from a branding and media background. Your listing won't look like every other MLS post — it'll have a visual identity, a story, and a reach strategy built for how people actually find homes today: Instagram, Google, targeted outreach, not just the MLS syndication everyone gets by default.

THE LIFESTYLE SELLS THE BLOCK

Buyers aren't just buying your home — they're buying the block, the walk to the coffee shop, the Sunday morning routine. I market the neighborhood alongside the property because that's what gets people emotionally committed to writing an offer.

Strong marketing is a coordinated launch, not a single pretty photo. Judge it by the first two weeks — that's when urgency is built or lost.

The highest offer isn't always the *best* one.

Offer day is when all the preparation pays off. But reading offers isn't as simple as comparing numbers — the terms, the financing, and the people behind the offer all matter.

HOW OFFERS WORK HERE

The offer date — In SF, we typically set a deadline for offers after the first round of open houses. This creates a structured process that generates competition and lets us compare offers side by side.

Earnest money — The buyer's good-faith deposit, typically 3% of the purchase price in SF. A larger deposit signals serious intent.

Contingencies — Inspection, financing, and appraisal contingencies protect the buyer but create uncertainty for you. In competitive situations, buyers often waive some or all of them — which is good for certainty, but comes with nuance I'll walk you through.

WHAT MAKES AN OFFER STRONG

- **Financing strength** — cash or a fully underwritten loan beats a pre-approval letter every time.
- **Clean terms & few contingencies** — fewer outs for the buyer means more certainty for you.
- **Close date that fits you** — timing matters, especially if you're buying simultaneously.
- **Deposit size & earnestness** — the size of the deposit and the buyer's willingness to go non-refundable early tells you how committed they are.

A RENT-BACK, AKA A SOFT LANDING

If you need to stay in your home after it closes — because your next place isn't ready, or you're still searching — we can negotiate a rent-back agreement. The buyer closes and takes title, but you remain as a tenant for an agreed period (usually up to 60 days). It's common in SF, and it's one of the most powerful tools for managing the sell-then-buy juggle.



What really *hits* your net.

The sale price is not the number you walk away with. Between commissions, transfer taxes, and closing costs, the gap can be significant — and in San Francisco, the transfer tax alone is one of the biggest line items.

SF TRANSFER TAX — THE BIG LOCAL LINE

Up to \$250,000	0.50%
\$250,001–\$999,999	0.68%
\$1M–\$4.99M	0.75%
\$5M–\$9.99M	2.25%
\$10M and above	5.5%–6%

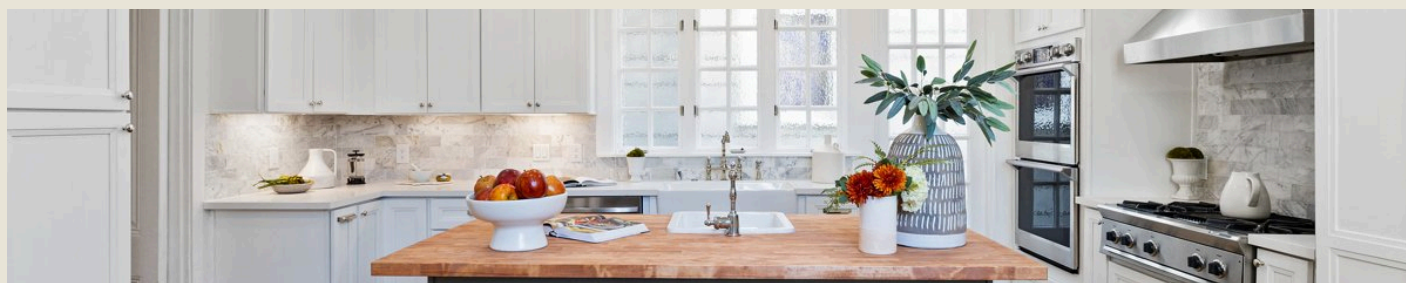
Brackets apply to the entire sale price, not just the portion above each threshold. Rates can change — I'll confirm the current schedule when we build your net sheet.

THE REST OF THE NET SHEET

- **Commissions** — typically the largest cost. I'll explain how they work and what you're actually paying for.
- **Staging & prep** — varies widely. Could be \$0 if your home shows well as-is, or \$5,000–\$15,000+ for a full staging and refresh.
- **Reports & inspections** — pest, general inspection, 3R, NHD — budget \$2,000–\$4,000 for a typical package.
- **Title & escrow fees** — shared with the buyer in most SF transactions. Your portion is typically \$3,000–\$6,000.
- **Buyer credits/concessions** — sometimes a buyer asks the seller to contribute toward their closing costs. Negotiable.
- **Mortgage payoff** — your remaining loan balance, plus any prepayment penalties (rare, but check).

CAPITAL GAINS — THE ONE TO RAISE WITH YOUR CPA

If you've lived in your home for at least two of the last five years, you may exclude up to \$250,000 in capital gains (\$500,000 for married couples filing jointly) from federal taxes. Beyond that threshold, gains are taxable — and California has its own layer. This is CPA territory, not Realtor territory, but I'll make sure the question gets raised early so there are no surprises.



The whiplash — and how people *pull it off*.

If you're selling your current home and buying your next one, you already know the anxiety: what if I sell before I find something? What if I find something and can't sell fast enough? It's the classic timing puzzle, and there are real strategies for navigating it.

BUY FIRST

Bridge financing

If you have the financial flexibility, buying first removes the pressure of finding your next home on a deadline. A bridge loan lets you tap your current equity for the down payment before your home sells. It's not free money — there are costs and qualification requirements — but for many sellers it's the cleanest path to avoiding the gap.

SELL FIRST

The rent-back

Sell your home, negotiate a rent-back for 30–60 days, and use that time (and your sale proceeds) to buy your next place with certainty. You know exactly what you have to spend, and you're a stronger buyer because of it. The trade-off: you're house-hunting on a deadline, and the rent-back period isn't unlimited.

THE HARD TRUTH

Contingent offers are weak here

In most SF markets, an offer contingent on selling your current home will lose to a clean, non-contingent offer. It's not impossible — but it requires the right market conditions and a cooperating seller on the other side. We plan around this reality rather than hoping for it.

HOW WE CHOREOGRAPH IT

Every sell-and-buy scenario is different, and the right strategy depends on your finances, your timeline, and how competitive your buy-side market is. I'll map out the options specific to your situation — including lender introductions, rent-back strategy, and timing — so you're not guessing. This is coordination work, and it's where having one agent on both sides (or at least a team that talks) makes a real difference.



Escrow, keys, *done*.

The hard part is over — you've accepted an offer and you're in escrow. Now it's about logistics, loose ends, and making sure the handoff is clean. Here's what to have on your radar.

BEFORE YOU HAND OVER THE KEYS

- **Transfer utilities** — PG&E, water, Recology (trash), internet. Set your end dates for the day after closing (or after your rent-back ends).
- **Final professional cleaning** — deliver the home in the condition you'd want to receive it. A deep clean is standard and expected.
- **Gather every key, remote & code** — garage openers, mailbox keys, gate codes, alarm PINs. Make a complete set for the buyer.
- **Manuals & warranties** — appliance manuals, warranty info, contractor contacts. Leave them in a folder on the kitchen counter.
- **Forward your mail** — set up USPS forwarding at least two weeks before closing. It takes a few days to activate.



WHAT I'M HANDLING IN THE BACKGROUND

While you're packing boxes, I'm tracking escrow timelines, coordinating with the buyer's agent, confirming the buyer's loan is on track, scheduling the final walk-through, and making sure nothing falls through the cracks between acceptance and recording.

You'll know what's happening at every step — but you won't have to manage it.

A NOTE TO END ON

Sell it well, and *on your terms.*

Selling a home is a financial event, but it's also a life event. You're closing a chapter — and that deserves an agent who respects both the money and the moment.

I hope this guide gave you a clearer picture of what's ahead. If it raised questions, good — that means you're thinking about it the right way. And when you're ready to talk about your specific home, your specific neighborhood, and your specific goals, I'm here.

No pressure. No pitch. Just an open door.

— *claudia lee*

Free 20-minute consult — bring your questions, I'll give it to you straight.

BOOK A CALL

claudia@vantagesanfrancisco.com · @claudiainsider

claudiainsider.com

DRE #02380540

Claudia Lee · REALTOR® · Vantage Realty · San Francisco

